

Curiosity Rewards



QUESTION 1

What fruits and animals are depicted in this painting?

Art History **Biology**

This 1602 still life painting by Spanish Baroque artist Juan Sánchez Cotán is a classic example of the **bodegón**, a genre of Spanish kitchen or pantry still life. The subjects are carefully arranged within a stone window frame (called a **cantarero**) against a dramatic dark background.

****Fruits:****

- ****Quinces (or lemons):**** The bright yellow, lumpy fruits hanging in the upper left corner, still attached to a branch with green leaves. While they resemble lemons, their bumpy texture suggests they may be quinces, a fruit common in 17th-century

Spain.

- **Apples:** A cluster of small, reddish-yellow apples suspended by an intricate arrangement of strings in the center of the composition.

Animals:

All of the animals depicted are birds, representing typical game hunted for food during the period:

- **Game birds:** Two larger birds hang prominently in the upper center, likely **partridges** (possibly red-legged partridges, native to Spain) or a **duck**, displayed upside down.
- **Small songbirds:** Several smaller birds, likely **thrushes**, **finches**, or **sparrows**, are visible. A group of these small birds is skewered together on a piece of cane or reed leaning against the left wall, while a couple hang individually by strings near the top.

Also notable: The painting includes several vegetables on the stone ledge — **carrots** (including heritage purple/red varieties), a **parsnip** or **white radish**, and a large sweeping **cardoon** (a relative of the artichoke) on the right.

Sánchez Cotán is considered a pioneer of the *bodegón* genre. His compositions are famous for their mathematical arrangement of objects along a hyperbolic curve, hyperrealistic detail, and dramatic lighting that elevates humble pantry items into something almost spiritual.

FLORIDA EDUCATIONAL STANDARDS (CPALMS)

VA.912.H.1.2 — Describe the significance of major works of art and explain why they are important to the culture and history of the time period.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4754>

VA.912.C.1.2 — Use critical-thinking skills for various contexts to develop, refine, and reflect on an artistic theme.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4738>

VA.912.H.1.4 — Apply background knowledge and personal interpretation to discuss cross-cultural connections among various artworks and the individuals, groups, events, and/or traditions they reflect.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4756>

QUESTION 2

What does the composition and lighting tell us about the artist's technique?

Art History Visual Arts Mathematics

This painting, **Still Life with Game Fowl, Vegetables and Fruits** by Juan Sánchez Cotán (1602), is a masterful example of Spanish Baroque still life painting, and its composition and lighting reveal several sophisticated techniques.

****Lighting — Tenebrism and Chiaroscuro:**** Cotán uses an extreme contrast between a pitch-black background and brightly illuminated foreground objects, a technique known as ****tenebrism**** (an intense form of chiaroscuro). A single, strong light source from the upper left strikes each object, casting subtle shadows on the stone ledge and creating a striking three-dimensional, almost hyperrealistic effect. This directional lighting allows the viewer to perceive different surface textures — the waxy skin of lemons and apples, the detailed feathers on the game birds, and the pale, fibrous stalks of the cardoon (the large celery-like vegetable on the right). Each material reflects and absorbs light differently, demonstrating Cotán's sophisticated understanding of how light interacts with surfaces.

****Composition — Geometric and Mathematical Order:**** The objects are arranged within a shallow stone window frame (called a **cantarero**), which acts like a stage. The placement of items is far from random. If you trace a line from the hanging lemons at the top left, down through the suspended apples and birds, across the carrots on the ledge, and then up along the sweeping curve of the cardoon on the right, the objects follow a ****hyperbolic or parabolic curve****. This mathematical arrangement gives the painting a sense of deliberate rhythm and balance, suggesting that Cotán saw nature as governed by an underlying geometric harmony. The clear spacing and strong outlines also ensure each item is read distinctly, almost like a catalog of natural textures and forms.

****Realism and the Bodegón Tradition:**** The meticulous rendering of every surface demonstrates Cotán's deep commitment to ****naturalism**** — making humble

kitchen items look so real they seem to occupy the viewer's own space (an effect called *trompe l'oeil*). This work helped establish the *bodegón* (Spanish kitchen still life) as a serious artistic genre, elevating everyday food items to subjects worthy of the same careful attention as religious or historical paintings. Overall, the composition and lighting reveal an artist whose technique combined intense visual observation with careful mathematical planning to create depth, realism, and visual intensity.

FLORIDA EDUCATIONAL STANDARDS (CPALMS)

VA.912.C.1.2 — Use critical-thinking skills for various contexts to develop, refine, and reflect on an artistic theme.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4808>

VA.912.H.1.2 — Analyze the influence of a significant collection of art and artifacts from a major period in art history.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4854>

VA.912.S.1.4 — Demonstrate effective use of art media, techniques, and processes in observational and inventive works of art.

Visual Arts | Grade 9-12

<https://www.cpalms.org/Public/PreviewStandard/Preview/4870>